Here’s What I Learned in Field Experience

Throughout my observation experiences, I learned a great deal about classroom management, student engagement, and effective teaching strategies. Observing the different classrooms helped me identify some techniques I would like to use in my own teaching, as well as some approaches I would handle differently.

One of the biggest things I learned was the value of effective classroom management. In the second-grade classroom, students always had a lot of energy, but I noticed that the teacher used strategies such as asking questions, giving quiet reminders, and counting down to regain their attention. I found these techniques interesting because they helped redirect students without always resorting to discipline. However, I also questioned some stricter approaches, such as threatening to take away recess. I want to be able to maintain classroom structure while still creating a positive environment where students feel comfortable and respected.

I also learned how important repetition and student engagement are, especially when teaching reading. The second-grade teacher regularly used flashcards, repeated sounds, and carefully pronounced new words to reinforce learning. Stories, music, and games also seemed to keep students interested and help them remember what they learned. These observations reinforced my belief that effective teaching involves finding creative ways to present engaging information while giving students plenty of opportunities to practice.

In the English classroom, I was interested to see fewer formal assessments than I was used to from my own school experience. Most of the things assigned by either teacher were more game than assessment. One used a maze where students answered questions to advance, which made the assessment more interactive and enjoyable. I also noticed how effectively the teacher used short guiding questions to check understanding and reinforce vocabulary. Developing this skill is one of my goals because I want to ask questions that are clear, engaging, and encourage critical thinking. I also had opportunities to read aloud to students and talk with them about their books and assignments. I felt that my reading went well, even though I had limited time to prepare. When speaking with students, I asked about their books, what had happened so far, and what they thought would happen next. Although I could improve my questioning by encouraging students to explain their thinking in greater depth, I was reminded that teaching requires not only presenting and assessing information but also helping students think critically about what they are learning.

Finally, observing stories about refugees, war, and abuse reminded me of the importance of considering students' emotional well-being when selecting reading material. Although students seemed to handle the stories well, I wondered how teachers should respond if a student found the material upsetting. I also wondered if there were any warnings about the material before the students read the stories or not.

Overall, this experience helped me better understand the responsibilities involved in teaching. I learned that successful instruction requires a balance of classroom management, engaging activities, clear explanations, and meaningful student interaction. I also realized that not every teaching strategy will work for every student. Moving forward, I want to continue developing my questioning techniques, create engaging lessons, and build a classroom environment that encourages learning while making students feel supported and respected.